

Hard drive warranties lowered

Three of the major hard drive makers have cut down the length of warranties from three years to one year on some of their drives, starting October 1 2002. PC makers have been pulling back the warranties on their computers in an effort to reduce costs, and hard-drive makers Seagate, Maxtor and Western Digital are following suit. These three giants comprise 85 per cent of the hard drive market.



The changes will only be for drives sold for desktop PCs and some consumer-electronics products, which traditionally have one-year warranties or less, according to representatives from all three companies. "We're following the trend in desktop PCs, where they've all switched to one-year warranties," said Stephen DiFranco, vice president of marketing at Maxtor.

"This should have no effect on consumers because we hardly ever get returns in the second or third year and it frees up cash that we have to reserve to cover the warranties."

The companies will maintain three and five-year warranties for drives used in large businesses such as banks. Western Digital will offer extended warranties directly to customers, while Maxtor and Seagate expect retailers to have extended warranty programs.

redalert

Bugbear

Infections by the new Bugbear worm (also known as Tanatos) have rocketed overnight. In just the first day of the worm being released, there were over 22,000 new infections. Asia and the Far East have been the worst hit areas, with the US a close second. The worm copies itself into the Windows system directory and startup folder as an EXE file with a random three-letter name. Once installed, it disables anti-virus and firewall software and installs a Trojan keystroke logger as a DLL, detected as PWS-Hooker.dll. The worm also seeks to infect all other PCs on the network via the address book and network shares. All major anti-virus companies have provided updates for their software to remove the virus.

Opasoft

Another worm that targets Windows 95, 98 and Me is called Opasoft, W32/Opasoft, or Opaserv. Unlike other worms that spread over the Internet through infected e-mail, Opasoft uses the NET-BIOS protocol. Once it hits a machine, it scans the network for other machines to attack. When a vulnerable machine is located, it checks if the C drive can be accessed, places a copy of itself on that machine and then alters the win.ini file so that the worm is run the next time the machine is started. Although the damage it does is not known, it opens a back door to www.opasoft.com, from which updated versions of the worm and other script files are downloaded. Anti-virus updates should be able to take care of the virus.

Need more space?

Sanyo Electric has introduced a drive which can read and write twice the amount of data onto conventional CD-Rs. When data is recorded with the new CRD-BPDV2 drive, a meagre 700 MB CD-R can hold 1.4 GB of data, that's up to 2 hours of video!



Sanyo's HD-Burn technology increases the data storage density by increasing the number of usable pits into which data is burnt. The company plans to start mass production in January next year, aiming at manufacturing 30,000 units a month.

FBI names top security flaws

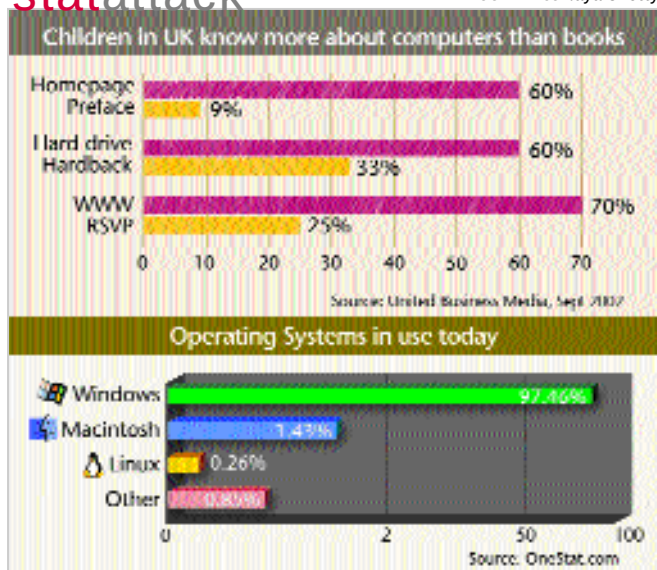
With an eye on taking the ease out of hacking, the FBI and SysAdmin, Audit, Networking and Security (SANS) Institute have announced two Top Twenty Internet Security Vulnerabilities for 2002. This list outlines the software features most often used by hackers to circumvent computer security and break into Windows and Unix systems.

As part of the announcement, federal agencies have been urged to test their networks for systems with any of the listed risks.

The SANS Institute was also planning a weekly critical vulnerability analysis mailing list. This will rely on a committee of 15 security professionals to decide which of the dozens of vulnerabilities found each week should receive special attention. In addition, it intends to develop a broader list of potential security problems to give companies further guidance on the security of their networks.

statattack

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■ Microsoft recruits Xbox hackers to crack down on illegal mod chips ■ Fujitsu promises to replace 3,00,000 HDDs due to faulty semiconductors